Passion for Life.

Preparing for your Master Thesis

SRH Fernhochschule – The Mobile University



Please introduce yourself using the chat

- I am joining today from …
- My study program is …
- I may have the following idea regarding a potential topic of my Master Thesis …
- Regarding the Master Thesis I am most interested in these aspects …

Our goals today

- Overview regarding the process of preparing the Master Thesis
- Awareness, why it is worth starting early with selecting possible topics
- Typical mistakes
- Addressing your questions

Agenda

01 Introduction

02 Requirements

03 Milestones

04 Drafting a Master Thesis

05 Structure of a Master Thesis

06 Grading a Master Thesis

07 Colloquium

Introduction

01

Purpose of the Master Thesis

The Master Thesis provides evidence of the ability to **work independently** on a problem from among the subject areas of the master's degree using **scientific methods** within a specified period of time.

Requirements

02

Scientific requirements

- Research of current and relevant literature
- Critical evaluation of the literature
- Self-critical interpretation of the results
- Proof of knowledge of the principles of scientific work

Practice-related requirements

- Linkage with a concrete problem of operational reality
- Own investigations and analyses to a practical issue according to the principles of scientific research
- Stringent, logical and transparent deduction of the analysis and examination results
- Correct application of scientific methods

Ethics in research

Researchers are responsible for their actions – and the potential impact of these actions on others. This also applies to you and your project and research work.

Principles of research ethics:

- Respect for the autonomy of participants (informed consent)
- Prevention of harm (non-maleficence)
- Maximization of benefits (beneficence)
- Justice (fairness)
- Data protection and confidentiality
- Accountability and transparency
- Scientific integrity



Incorporate these principles into your project work and its coordination process as early as possible: already as part of the planning phase!

Milestones

03

Milestones

1. Identification of a suitable topic for the Master Thesis
2. Agreement on the proposed topic with a selected thesis supervisor
3. Creation of an exposé (synopsis) for the Master Thesis, in coordination with the thesis supervisor
4. Submission of the exposé to the course director by the thesis supervisor
5. Approval of the synopsis by the course director
6. Official confirmation of the topic for the Master Thesis by the university
7. Drafting of the Master Thesis

Identification of a suitable topic

1. Topic selection

- Personal interests
- Academic need for research
- Business needs

2. Topic evaluation

- List of thematic areas of interest & research of our professors
- Checking relevance together with the supervisor
- Checking feasibility together with the supervisor

Coordinating the content

Initial contact with selected thesis supervisor by e-mail:

- What is the problem to be addressed by the thesis?
- What is the objective of the thesis?
- Which are possible key questions to be answered?
- Which specific research methods are to be applied?
- Will the final thesis be confidential?

Drafting the exposé

An exposé has 5-7 pages, is mandatory and serves these purposes:

- Defining the question
- Specifying the objectives
- Laying out the plan of action

Exposé
Scientific information

Title

The title of the thesis will be final upon official confirmation of the topic for the Master Thesis by the university.

Subsequently, the title of the thesis could only be changed in justified, exceptional cases, with approval by the course director.

Exposé
Scientific information

The problem to be addressed

- What is the problem area to be addressed by the thesis?
- Why is the problem a problem?
- Describing the point of departure
- Justifying the relevance of the problem

Exposé
Scientific information

Objective of the thesis und key questions

- Which specific questions are to be addressed?
- Which specific answers is the thesis to deliver?

Exposé
Scientific information

Methods to be applied

- Process to be followed to derive answers to the key questions
- Presentation of the main content to be covered by the thesis

Exposé
Other information

- Proposed table of contents of the thesis
- Bibliography
- Rationale for topic selection
- Support extended by employer
- Resources required
- Time schedule for thesis completion

Further details on the Master Thesis

2-year Master programs (120 ECTS)	1.5-year Master programs (90 ECTS)	1-year Master programs (60 ECTS)
Registration of thesis At the earliest: After completion of at least 78 ECTS have been earned.	**Registration of thesis** At the earliest: After completion of at least 54 ECTS have been earned.	**Registration of thesis** At the earliest: After completion of at least 30 ECTS have been earned.
Credit points 30 ECTS	**Credit points** 24 ECTS	**Credit points** 18 ECTS
Processing period 6 months (An extension by 3 months can be granted upon request)	**Processing period** 5 months (An extension by 3 months can be granted upon request)	**Processing period** 4 months (An extension by 3 months can be granted upon request)
Length of thesis 60 to 80 pages of text (without graphics and tables). Please coordinate details with your supervisor.		

Drafting a Master Thesis

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Steps to be followed

- Literature research (primarily online)
- Discussions with professionals/ experts
- In most cases: conducting surveys (100+ respondents) and/or expert interviews (5+ interviews)
- Analysis of the empirical data generated
- Drafting and finalization
- Submission of thesis in the e-campus

Structure of a Master Thesis

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Overview

Your Master Thesis should ..

- satisfy scientific requirements
- be structured clearly
- guide through your topic in a logical way
- allow your work and results to be replicated by another researcher

- **Length: 60 to 80 pages**

5 main questions

1. Relevance
2. Prior findings
3. Methods
4. Results
5. Discussion

Elements of a Master Thesis

Cover Page

Abstract

Table of Contents

List of Charts

List of Tables

Glossary

1. Introduction
2. Theoretical part
3. Methods

4 Results

5 Discussion

6. Conclusion and outlook

Bibliography

Annexes (if any)

Elements of a Master Thesis
1. Introduction

- Statement of the problem/ relevance
- Objectives
- Content limits: What is the thesis about? And what is it not about?
- Overview of the further analysis (structure of the thesis)

Elements of a Master Thesis
2. Theoretical part

- Presenting the theoretical foundations
- Analyzing the current state of empirical research related to the topic
- Compressing theoretical foundations and related empirical results
- Further specification of the problem (hypothesis/ guiding questions)

Elements of a Master Thesis
3. Methods

Presenting the procedures for testing the hypotheses:

- Where?
- With whom?
- When?
- How?

Elements of a Master Thesis
4. Results

- Presenting the results as they relate to the hypotheses
- First purely descriptive
- If hypothesis have to be tested: inferential statistical analysis/ results

Elements of a Master Thesis
5. Discussion

- Critical reflection
- Interpretation of results
- Summary and conclusions
- Implications for business practice
- Implications for further research

Other elements

- Cover page
- Abstract
- Table of contents
- List of charts
- List of tables
- Glossary
- Bibliography
- Annexes

Grading a Master Thesis

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Grading

- Grading of the Master Thesis consists of an assessment of the written thesis and an assessment of the oral colloquium.
- The Master Thesis will be graded by the thesis supervisor. Grading should take place within 4 weeks of submission of the written thesis.
- If the thesis is graded less than satisfactory (below German grade 4,0), it can be repeated and resubmitted once by the student.

Grading

The assessment of the Master Thesis takes into account both content and formal requirements. Content includes all of the scientific requirements, i. e. the following aspects :

- Own literature research
- Currency and completeness of the scientific literature used
- Critical statement on the literature and comparison of different concepts
- Compliance with the criteria of scientific work
- Correctness of references, bibliography, citation etc.
- “Modest” and self-critical reasoning

Grading

In addition, practical requirements also play a role, especially in empirical work:

- A clear link to the problem of operational reality
- Carrying out your own investigations and analyzes in practice according to the principles of scientific research projects (e. g. empirical investigations, surveys, questionnaires, interviews, etc.),
- A well-founded and stringent derivation of the results
- Relevance of the results for practice
- Demonstrating specific and manageable solutions to the initial problem or underlying question

Oral Colloquium

07

Information

- The oral colloquium takes place online and will be recorded by the university
- Set an appointment for a suitable date and time with the thesis supervisor
- Total time: up to 45 minutes, of which
  - 20 minutes for the presentation by the thesis author (based on power point slides to be presented by the author),
  - followed by Q&A

Questions?

Thank you for your attention!

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